

Transition Contractions are intense and frequent as the cervix dilates fully. Systemic (IV) analgesics aren't usually given this close to the birth since they could affect the baby. If you have an epidural already in place, this can be topped off.

Second and third stages Stage two lasts from full dilation of the cervix until birth; contractions are strong and longer lasting, but easier to manage since you start pushing. Analgesics may be used. In the third stage, delivery of the placenta, contractions are mild and you shouldn't need pain relief.